

Bring 'Em Back. Please!

Every time a new phone is announced, I secretly (and hopelessly) wish for it to be a compact phone, only to go back to my chair and convince myself that it's over. Am I the last man standing when it comes to compact smartphones? Is our ever-shrinking "compact phone crusade" about to die in the hands of the big-screen fanatics?

Some of my favorite (and fairly recent) phones from a form factor perspective - the Google Pixel 5, and the Apple iPhone 11 Pro to name a few, have been my poster boys from an ideal package point of view. They were all about high performance in a compact package that didn't need me to stretch my thumb and juggle around just to reach the top left corner of the screen. You could use them with just one hand and looking back, I realize what a luxury it was. Today, with most phones, be it flagship, midrange, or budget, you simply cannot single-handedly navigate the length and breadth of the screen. And for some reason, phones are not just larger, they are getting heavier and thicker, making them even more unwieldy on a day-to-day basis. For sure, there is a market for compact phones, it's just that phone manufacturers are too busy looking at the "bigger picture" where larger-sized phones are increasingly finding acceptance, especially in a country like ours where the smartphone is the first and only screen/device for a significant percentage of users when it comes to consuming content. And that's a valid reason for the focus to be on big-screen smartphones.

It's disappointing to see phone manufacturers completely disregarding the potential market for compact phones. The smartphone industry is reaching a saturation point when it comes to innovation and differentiation, brands are struggling to stand out and offer something truly unique. And perhaps catering to a niche segment of compact smartphone buyers could be a game-changer, just the right kind of fundamental differentiation that attracts demand and also builds consumer loyalty. If manufacturers could offer compact phones across price segments, from the 15K range to 50K, it would open up a whole new market. Sadly, budget and mid-range buyers have been



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left without a compact phone option for too long, forcing them to compromise every time they upgrade. This is akin to what auto enthusiasts are experiencing in India, with the lack of performance-oriented hatchback cars. Instead, the auto industry is busy creating pseudo SUVs, Compact SUVs, Mini SUVs, and crossovers masquerading themselves as SUVs. The VW Polo GT is dead and you only have the Hyundai N-Line that barely passes muster when it comes to performance hatchbacks. The fundamental argument, whether it be in the world of smartphones or cars, is to cater to niche markets. Especially in large and growing markets like ours. However, this requires whole-hearted efforts, from product development to marketing and after-sales support. Manufacturers must recognize the potential market for compact phones and make a sincere effort to serve it, rather than blindly chasing trends that may not ultimately pay off.

After a brief discussion with the editing team about compact phones, several arguments for and against their production emerged. Ultimately, personal preferences play a significant role, but the conversation returned to the economic feasibility of manufacturing compact phones. The main argument against it is that creating a compact phone would require non-standardized components, including the display, PCB, and battery. This would increase manufacturing costs, as these components would need to come from a non-standard assembly line. However, smaller phones could use smaller displays and batteries, which might balance out the overall Bill Of Materials (BOM) cost. Therefore, in my opinion, making compact phones may not be a prohibitively expensive affair, but it remains an unexplored area that brands are avoiding in order not to upset the status quo.

I firmly believe there's a sizable demand and market for compact phones, across price segments, and it's an opportunity that lay wasted. What are your thoughts on compact smartphones? Or even on the extinct breed of performance hatchbacks (hot hatches as they are lovingly called). Write to me at soham@digit.in, I am keen to know if I am the last man standing. 